

FASHION ICON

TWIGGY



△ MOD HAIRCUT

Few women could carry off hairdresser Vidal Sassoon's severe five-point cut as well as gamine-faced Twiggy. Her crop hairstyle became an integral part of the mod look of the 1960s.

ANDROGYNOUS TREND 1968 ▷

Twiggy is best known for modelling ultra-feminine baby-doll dresses. But she was equally at ease in traditional menswear adapted for women's fashion.

London model Twiggy, born Lesley Hornby, shot to fame in 1966, her face imprinted on the decade. London youth fashions dominated the world and Twiggy was the ideal international ambassador and one of the first supermodels. The teenager's girlish, twig-like figure, short hair, wide, darkly lined and long-lashed eyes (with extra lower lashes painted on her skin), freckles, and innocent expression added up to a waif-like gamine look that spoke to ordinary young women.

The mini-girl in the mini-era

Twiggy – from her existing nickname Twigs – was an unlikely icon at just 16 years of age. She was short for a model, at 1.68 m (5ft 6 in), with a silhouette and appearance totally different from the curvier, sophisticated models of the day. Her look was a striking version of the mod – a crucial youth-cult link.

Admiring a photograph of the young girl sporting a striking crop on the walls of a London hair salon, *Daily Express* journalist Deirdre McSharry asked to meet her. Soon Twiggy was splashed across the paper as "The Face of '66". That same year saw her in a *Vogue* shoot and, by the following year, she had her own line of dresses and was a top international model, managed by boyfriend Justin de Villeneuve. Throughout 1966 and 67 she was featured in magazines such as *Vogue* and *Elle*, in France, the UK, and the US. Legendary US *Vogue* editor Diana Vreeland championed Twiggy and gave her career a powerful boost.

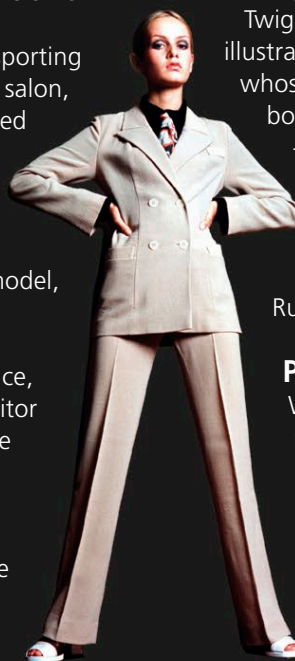
Much has been said about Twiggy starting the trend for super-thin models. But she has countered that she was very young when she began modelling, ate heartily, was naturally skinny, and disapproves of size zero.

Twiggy's status as one of the era's most photographed people helped to promote many of the main fashion trends of the 1960s. Her short hair and underdeveloped figure made her perfect for the little boy/little girl look that revolutionized fashion from Europe to North America and through to Australasia. The look included the baby doll style and pale tights of London designers such as Jean Varon and Gina Fratini, and the work of younger Parisian designers such as Pierre Cardin and Emmanuelle Khanh. Twiggy modelled countless variations of the all-important simple 60s mini-shift, including Yves Saint Laurent's landmark 1967 African collection, which featured revealing shift dresses made from raffia, shells, and wooden beads. She was the first model to design her own range of clothing, and her line included dresses in trendy psychedelic colouring.

Twiggy's big-eyed innocence was echoed in fashion illustration, particularly in the catalogues for Biba, whose clothes she modelled. And her cropped, boyish look brought back 1920s and 30s influences – such as flapper dresses and male-style suiting – in the 1960s and 70s. All this took just four years. She retired from modelling in 1970 to focus on acting and singing, reinforcing 1920s fashions further by appearing in Ken Russell's film *The Boy Friend*, released in 1971.

Promoting the mature woman

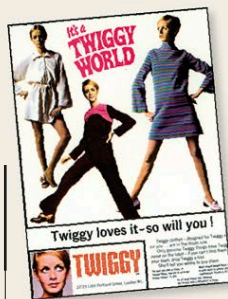
While following a varied subsequent career in music, acting, and TV, Twiggy maintained links with the fashion world, including designing clothes. Later modelling included a key role in a high-profile Marks & Spencer womenswear campaign from 2005 onwards, as well as a broader role as an advocate of stylish clothes for mature women.



TIMELINE

1949 Born Lesley Hornby in Neasden, northwest London

1965 Meets hairdresser Nigel Davies, who renames himself Justin de Villeneuve and becomes her manager



1966 Launches modelling career and advertises her Twiggy Dresses clothes line for teenage market. Voted British Woman of the Year

1967 The Twiggy Phenomenon causes a stir in New York and Twiggy appears on cover of US *Vogue*

1969 Cast in Ken Russell's film, *The Boy Friend*, released in 1971



1970 Retires from modelling

2005 Takes part in the first Marks and Spencer womenswear ad campaign featuring women of different ages. Becomes a judge on TV's *America's Next Top Model*

2009 Featured in exhibition *The Model as Muse: Embodying Fashion* at New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art

○ 1960

○ 1970

○ 2010